

HP LaserJet 3052 All-in-One and 3055 All-in-One

Something decent for the mid-range

HP takes care of the mid-range segment in the form of its LaserJet 3052 and 3055 All-in-One MFDs. These are identical in all but one aspect: the 3055 has a fax.



HP LaserJet 3052
All In One

These MFDs occupy 49.7 x 40.6 cm, which is on the higher side, but they weigh just 12.4 kg. The input tray holds 250 sheets, and an additional 10 in the "priority tray." The output tray holds a hundred prints, and the ADF holds 50 sheets.

The control panel is intuitive, with a two-line, 16-character backlit display. The 3055 also has an alphanumeric fax dialling keypad. This keypad is also there on the 3052, which does not have a fax unit, so they are only for input.

These MFDs feature high-resolution printers: 1200 x 1200 dpi. The input buffer is 64 MB, which is sufficient for large print jobs and long queues. The warm-up time we recorded was about 49 seconds. Text is crisp, and the legibility of fine print improves in the best mode, but greyscale graphics are not produced equally well.

The flatbed scanner supports 24-bit scanning at an optical resolution of 1200 x 1200 dpi, and this can be interpolated to up to 19,200 dpi. The drivers support both the WIA and the TWAIN interfaces. They clocked average speeds, and were able to resolve only two of the three blocks in our resolution chart. They did perform fairly well in the OCR test.

The first photocopy took 8.5 seconds—the fastest in this test. The copies were, however, a tad too dark.

These MFDs feature a 33.6 Kbps (about three seconds per page) fax with up to 110 pages of fax memory. The broadcasting and delayed fax features are standard, and you can broadcast to up to 119 locations. The MFDs feature an Ethernet ports as well as USB connectivity.

Both these models come with HP ToolBox FX, which allow you to monitor device status and also manage fax tasks and setup alerts. (Alerts are in the form of e-mail that is sent to you when events such as fax reception occur).

The monthly duty cycle here is 7,000 prints; other MFDs in this price range generally offer more. The cartridge has a duty cycle of 3,000 prints and costs Rs 2,961; cost per page works out to Rs 1.48, which is a bit steep.

The HP LaserJet 3052 and 3055 cost Rs 20,999 and Rs 24,499 respectively, and are almost at par with the Canon MF4122 and MF4150 in terms of speed, but trail the latter a little in terms of print quality.



HP LaserJet 3055
All In One

Lexmark X342n

Très élégant!

Lexmark has paid attention to looks here. This is a rather tall MFD with a grey plastic body, broad at the top and tapering towards the bottom. The bottom is rather narrow, but it still requires a considerable amount of desktop space, with a footprint of 53 x 39.4 cm. Aesthetics have little to do with ruggedness, unfortunately. The hinges and the trays of the X342n are built rather well, but the flaps (especially the extension flap of the ADF tray) are flimsy.

This MFD has one of the largest paper capacities of all those we tested; the input tray holds as many as 550 sheets, while the output tray, 150. The two-line LCD is backlit.

A niggles here—as you go deeper into the menu to make changes and then go back, you are not returned to the previous menu, but rather to the root menu. You therefore can't make many changes at once.

This Lexmark can print at 600 x 600 dpi, and has 32 MB of buffer (which takes care of larger documents and long print queues). It initialises very slowly, taking 48.3 seconds to warm up. Once warmed up, it is rather quick; our first text

copy printed in 11.4 seconds, and the rest at around 27 ppm. Our combi-document took a bit longer for the first copy in Draft mode: 17.9 seconds. It took a much longer 32.1 seconds in the best quality mode. The rest of the copies of the combi-document were printed even faster than 30 ppm in Draft mode—this was the first MFD of the lot to achieve this.

Text quality was generally good. The faint portions of the concentric pattern in Draft mode weren't perfect, but were fine in the best quality mode.

In addition to the sheet-fed scanner, there is a Legal-size flatbed scanner capable of scanning at 600 x 600 dpi. Scanner scores were below average here; the machine was able to differentiate between shades of grey, but failed to differentiate well between different colour shades in the mid-range colours of the Kodak IT8 chart. In our OCR test, it made way too many errors, and even failed to recognise bold and large fonts.

The first photocopy took 11.9 seconds, and the rest were produced in 4.4 seconds each. Text quality was good, but the graphics looked washed out.

The Lexmark X342n has a USB as well as an Ethernet port. It comes with Presto! PageManager which is an OCR software. Lexmark provides a high-yield 6,000 page duty cycle cartridge, which costs Rs 4,500, meaning a rather affordable 75 paise per page. Priced at Rs 23,900, this Lexmark seems to be a good buy on every front.

